Tattoo Machine



Category: **Beauty, Wellness & Fitness** Type: **Full SOP** Priority: **High** 3 labs

Covers these lab items: Tattooing set

What it is used for

A tattoo machine drives a needle cartridge or needle assembly to deposit tattoo pigment into the skin under controlled conditions. Safe operation requires appropriate training, sterile single-use needles, hygienic work practices, suitable equipment settings, and correct sharps disposal to reduce infection and injury risks.

Main parts

- Machine body houses the drive mechanism.
- Motor or electromagnetic coil drives the needle mechanism depending on the design.
- Grip provides a controlled handhold.
- Needle cartridge or needle assembly carries the needles.
- Power supply or battery controls machine operation.
- Foot pedal operates compatible wired machines where fitted.
- Connecting cable supplies power on wired models.
- Barrier covers help protect machine surfaces from contamination.
- Approved pigment cups hold small amounts of tattoo pigment.

Before you start

1. Tattooing should be performed only by trained personnel in compliance with applicable local laws and hygiene requirements.
2. Inspect the machine, grip, power supply, cable, and controls for damage before use.
3. Confirm that needles or cartridges are sterile, sealed, within expiry, and intended for single use.
4. Clean and disinfect the work area and use suitable barriers on surfaces and equipment.
5. Perform hand hygiene, wear new suitable gloves, and prepare clean supplies without contaminating sterile items.
6. Check that pigments are appropriate for tattooing, traceable, and stored according to their instructions.
7. Explain the procedure, obtain informed consent, check relevant contraindications, and follow appropriate skin-preparation procedures.

How to use

1. Prepare a clean, well-lit work area and organise clean and contaminated zones separately.
2. Cover machine surfaces, cables, and controls with appropriate single-use barriers where practical.

3. Open the sterile needle cartridge or needle assembly immediately before use without touching sterile parts.
4. Fit the needle assembly and grip securely according to the machine instructions.
5. Set the machine voltage, stroke, and needle depth only within the manufacturer's guidance and the operator's training.
6. Dispense pigment into single-use cups without contaminating the original containers.
7. Prepare the skin using an approved skin antiseptic and allow it to dry as directed.
8. Operate the machine with controlled hand movements and avoid excessive pressure or repeated trauma to the skin.
9. Monitor the client's comfort and skin response; stop if there is an unexpected reaction or significant bleeding.
10. After the procedure, switch off the machine and remove the needle assembly without touching exposed sharps.
11. Place used needles and other sharps immediately into an approved puncture-resistant sharps container.
12. Dispose of contaminated consumables according to applicable biomedical waste requirements and clean and disinfect reusable equipment.
13. Provide appropriate aftercare instructions and record the procedure and any adverse event according to local requirements.

⚠ Safety

- Never reuse needles, cartridges, pigment cups, or other items designated for single use.
- Use gloves, hand hygiene, barriers, and appropriate disinfection to prevent cross-contamination and bloodborne infection.
- Do not tattoo over infected, inflamed, or otherwise unsuitable skin; refer health concerns for appropriate assessment.
- Never recap used needles by hand or leave exposed sharps on the work surface.
- Use only pigments permitted for the intended use and follow their safety instructions.
- Stop immediately if the machine overheats, electrical insulation is damaged, or the client develops a serious reaction.

Care & storage

- Switch off and disconnect the machine before cleaning or changing compatible components.
- Clean and disinfect reusable parts using methods approved by the manufacturer; do not immerse electrical components unless expressly permitted.
- Inspect cables, grips, seals, and machine housing regularly for wear or damage.
- Store the machine and sterile supplies in a clean, dry, protected area.
- Arrange authorised servicing if the drive mechanism becomes irregular or the machine overheats.

Common mistakes to avoid

- Using a needle cartridge that is unsealed, expired, or previously used.
- Touching sterile needles or clean supplies with contaminated gloves.

- Using excessive needle depth, pressure, or repeated passes that unnecessarily injure skin.
- Failing to dispose of sharps promptly or disinfect the work area between clients.

Disclaimer: This SOP is prepared from general information available on the internet. For detailed instructions, refer to the manufacturer's original manual / file.